

THE ADVENT CLOCK

A FREE PRINTABLE SAMPLE • WITH ANSWERS



WHAT'S INSIDE

- The story of the Great Advent Clock
- How the countdown works
- Door One (word search) and Door Two (secret code)
- The solutions for both doors

HOW TO PRINT

- US Letter paper, portrait.
- Choose “Actual size” or “Fit”.
- Grab a pencil and an eraser.
- Answers are at the back. No peeking!

ENJOYED THESE PUZZLES?

The full book, *The Advent Clock*, is a paperback on Amazon.
Search Amazon for “*The Advent Clock* Blake La Pierre”.

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Every puzzle is checked by computer to have exactly one solution.

*More in *The Advent Clock* by Blake La Pierre on Amazon*

SNOWBERRY LODGE, DECEMBER

THE GREAT ADVENT CLOCK



Every December since 1926, the Great Advent Clock has stood in the lobby of the Snowberry Lodge, between the fireplace and the stairs: a tall case of dark walnut with a painted moon on its face and, below the face, twenty-four little doors, each no bigger than a playing card.

It was built by the village clockmaker, Barnaby Thrush, and it has been looked after ever since by his granddaughter, Mrs. Otilie Thrush, who is eighty-one, wears three cardigans at once, and knows more about puzzles than anyone on the mountain.

The tradition is simple. On the first of December Otilie hides the lodge's silver star, the one that goes on top of the great tree in the lobby, and the twenty-four little doors hold the clues to where it is. Each door has a tiny brass dial of letters. Dial the right word and the door springs open.

This year Otilie has gone to spend Christmas with her sister by the sea. She has left the manager, Mr. Humphrey Budd, a sealed envelope, a notebook of twenty-four puzzles, and strict instructions: *one door a day, no peeking, and the star goes on the tree at midnight on Christmas Eve.*

Mr. Budd, who is round and kind and hopeless at puzzles, has handed the notebook to you. His niece Winnie, fifteen and never without her detective's notebook, has appointed herself your assistant. Nobody has dared to argue.



BEFORE YOU BEGIN

HOW THIS BOOK WORKS



- ❖ **One door a day.** Each door has two facing pages: a short scene and the rules on the left, the puzzle on the right. You can of course go at your own speed; the puzzles do not depend on each other until Christmas Eve.
- ❖ **Find the word.** Every puzzle leads to exactly one answer word. The rules tell you how to read it out of the finished puzzle. Write it in the answer boxes.
- ❖ **Keep the key letter.** One answer box is drawn with a heavy border and a small key. That is the day's **key letter**. Copy it into the Door Log on page 9.
- ❖ **Stuck?** Every door has three hints at the back of the book, in three separate sections so you only see as much as you want: a **Nudge**, a **Foothold** and a **Last Step**. Full solutions come after the hints.
- ❖ **Checked by computer.** Every grid puzzle in this book was re-solved by a separate computer program to make sure it has exactly one solution, and every answer was checked letter by letter.
- ❖ **You will need** a pencil, an eraser, and on one or two days a little patience. No phone, app or internet is needed.

DECEMBER 1 · DOOR ONE

THE FIRST DOOR



Ottilie's notebook is bound in green cloth and smells of pine needles. The first page says only: *Start with something easy. Everybody deserves a warm-up.* Winnie reads it over your shoulder, sharpens two pencils, and hands you one. Outside, the first proper snow of the winter is settling on the car park, and in the kitchen someone is already melting chocolate. Door One is the lowest on the left, with a sprig of painted holly around its keyhole.

HOW TO SOLVE

Find every word from the list in the grid. Words run across, down or diagonally down-right, and they may share letters. When all the words are found, read the letters that were not used, row by row from the top left. They spell a short message.

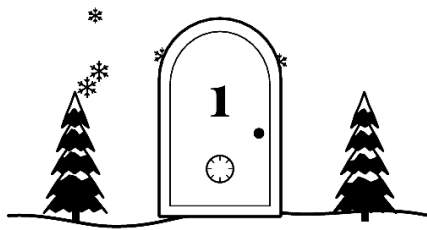
YOUR ANSWER



KEY

The heavy box is today's key letter. Copy it into the Door Log (page 9).

Hints: pages 61, 63 and 65 · Solution: page 67



DOOR ONE*December 1*

- ☐ CANDY
- ☐ GIFT
- ☐ MITTEN
- ☐ NORTH

- ☐ ROBIN
- ☐ SANTA
- ☐ SCARF
- ☐ SLED

- ☐ SNOW
- ☐ SOCKS
- ☐ STAR

DECEMBER 2 · DOOR TWO

A SECRET MESSAGE



Behind the first door you found a tiny wooden sleigh, painted red. Today the notebook holds a line of nonsense letters and a note: *Grandfather liked to move things along a little. Every letter here has taken the same number of steps along the alphabet, fewer than five.* Winnie is certain it is a code used by Roman generals. Mr. Budd is certain it is a shopping list. They are both a little bit right.

HOW TO SOLVE

Each letter of the message has been shifted forward along the alphabet by the same number of steps (after Z comes A again). Shift every letter back by that number to read the message. Try each number from 1 to 4 on the first word: only one gives English.

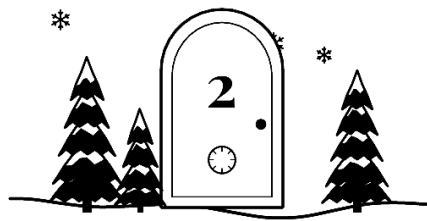
YOUR ANSWER



KEY

The heavy box is today's key letter. Copy it into the Door Log (page 9).

Hints: pages 61, 63 and 65 · Solution: page 68



DOOR TWO

December 2

K D Q J W K H J U H H Q

O H D Y H V D Q G U H G

E H U U L H V D E R Y H

H Y H U B G R R U .

W K H N H B L V

K R O O B .

ALPHABET STRIP (WRITE THE SHIFTED LETTERS UNDERNEATH IF IT HELPS)

A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I	J	K	L	M
N	O	P	Q	R	S	T	U	V	W	X	Y	Z

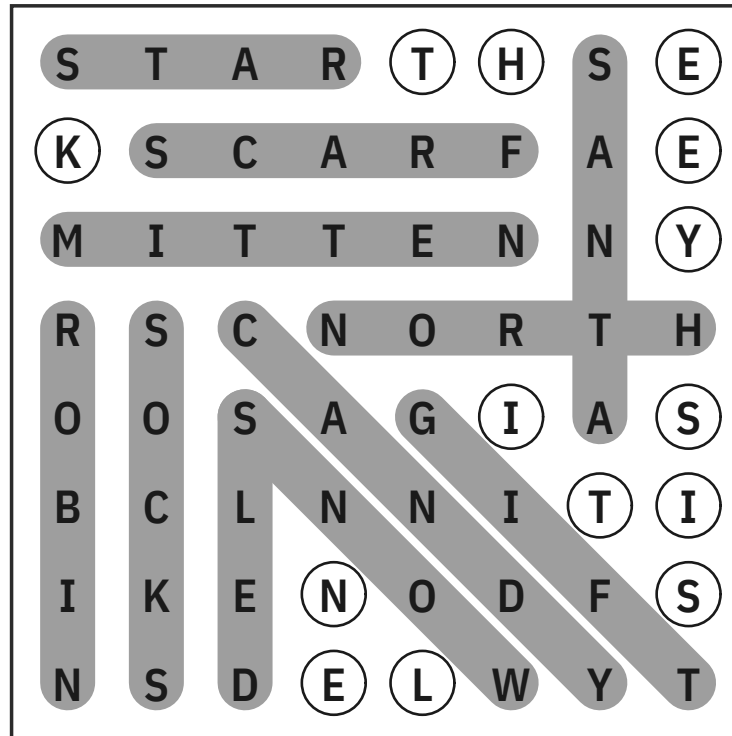
LOOK AWAY NOW IF YOU ARE STILL SOLVING

SOLUTIONS



DOOR ONE

Answer: TINSEL · key letter N



How it goes. With every word crossed out, the unused letters read THE KEY IS TINSEL. The key letter is the 3rd letter, N.

DOOR TWO

Answer: HOLLY · key letter H

Shift each letter back by 3: D→A, E→B, F→C ...

**HANG THE GREEN LEAVES AND RED BERRIES ABOVE
EVERY DOOR. THE KEY IS HOLLY.**

How it goes. Shifting back by 3 turns KDQJ into HANG, and the whole message reads as above. The key letter is the 1st letter, **H**.